

Editorial

To Connect Is Human

STATISTICS CAN SOMETIMES prove something. There are more than 1.1 billion Internet users; around three billion mobile phone users; a billion who use Internet Messengers and e-mail daily; and lately, a third of a billion on Web 2.0 sites—the now all-too-familiar Orkut and MySpace, and—the most interesting part—*Second Life*.

We've spoken about that online phenomenon quite early on in *Digit*, and even if most of us don't have the bandwidth to really be there, it's an *important* phenomenon.

Observe. There are two things central to all these popular manifestations of technology—they have raked in hundreds of millions of users in just five years, and, all of them have one core agenda—to link up human beings. They essentially foster increased communication, sharing of thoughts and opinions, and, exchange of content.

The second point deserves attention here—let me elaborate.

Any technology-led innovation that has met with instant success, been adopted globally, and topped popularity charts worldwide—language and cultural barriers notwithstanding—must satisfy one fundamental need of human beings: the need to socialise, express thoughts, and most pointedly, to communicate. We love to build communities, converse, and connect. If a technology helps us do these, we lap it up.

Why are MMORPGs such a rage, despite the fact that you can always play the game with a bot? That, I think, drives home my point. We want to connect—even if for a duel—with other people. Real people. Think about it... we might create virtual identities in *Second Life* and satisfy our desire to be that someone else, but eventually, we do it all to connect with other human beings (even if they're represented by a virtual identity themselves).

The achievements of these new technologies, if I may say so, also displace the popular notion that



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the increased usage of computers isolates people, even making them vulnerable, prone to loneliness and depression. If a “computer addict” is glued to social networking sites, it's not necessarily an instance of isolation. For many introverts, these sites are their only recourse when they feel the need for social interaction.

Networking sites—and now *Second Life*—becoming so popular clearly indicates that the success formula for any technological innovation in this space, to quickly scale up and find favour globally, is to bring in an element of human connect—even if it's virtual.

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'D. Ajwani'.

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